California creates new office to combat antisemitism in public schools - California Gov. Gavin Newsom signed a bill to create a statewide office to combat antisemitism in K-12 settings.

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California Gov. Gavin Newsom signed a bill Tuesday that creates a new statewide office tasked with rooting out antisemitism in public schools, the first of its kind in the country. Known as AB 715, the measure establishes a state Office of Civil Rights and mandates the appointment of an an antisemitism prevention coordinator, tasked with tracking complaints, issuing guidance, and coordinating training for educators. Supporters, including the California Legislative Jewish Caucus and Jewish advocacy groups, hailed the law as a necessary tool to protect Jewish students amid a surge in harassment and discrimination. "Today, California is sending a strong and unambiguous message — hate has no place in our schools and will not be tolerated," said Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel and Senator Scott Wiener, co-chairs of the caucus, in a statement. The first day of school (credit: SHUTTERSTOCK)The bill's unprecedented importanceA statement from Assemblymember Dawn Addis, a joint author of the bill, stressed that it represents an unprecedented response to antisemitism in K-12 settings. "This is a historic, first-in-the-nation effort that centers on the well-being of children across our state, many of whom bravely shared horrific stories about their experiences in our schools," Addis said. The path to the signing was contentious. The California Teachers Association, the ACLU, and numerous civil liberties organizations had urged Newsom to veto the bill, warning it could chill academic freedom and restrict teacher speech, especially around Israel. Opponents of AB 715, particularly those representing Arab, Muslim, and Palestinian communities, express concern that the law could suppress their voices in educational settings. Legal challenges are anticipated.

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